



# Azerbaijan



Situated on the western coast of the Caspian Sea, it was the first Soviet republic to declare independence in 1991.

Territorial disputes with Armenia have dominated politics since.



## GEOGRAPHY

Caucasus Mountains in west, including Naxçıvan exclave south of Armenia. Flat, low-lying terrain on the coast of the Caspian Sea.



## CLIMATE

Low rainfall. Continental, with bitter winters, inland. Subtropical in coastal regions.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Azeris, a Muslim people with ethnic links to Turks, form a large majority. Thousands of Armenians, Russians, and Jews have left since independence. Influx of half a million Azeri refugees fleeing war with Armenia over the disputed enclave of Nagorno-Karabakh. Armenians there operate with de facto independence. The status of women deteriorated after the fall of communism but they are slowly regaining their position.



## THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas exports drive economic growth. Pipeline to Ceyhan, Turkey, has opened up European market. Severe pollution in Baku.



**INSIGHT:** *The fire-worshipping Zoroastrian faith originated in Azerbaijan in the 6th century BCE*



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Azerbaijan

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1991

**CAPITAL:** Baku

**POPULATION:** 8.83 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 33,436 sq. miles  
(86,600 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 264 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Azeri\*, Russian

**RELIGIONS:** Shi'a Muslim 68%,  
Sunni Muslim 26%, Russian Orthodox 3%,  
Armenian Orthodox 2%, other 1%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Azeri 91%, other 3%,  
Lazs 2%, Russian 2%, Armenian 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** New manat = 100 gopik